MOLECULAR GRAPH CLASSIFICATION USING THE WEISFEILER–LEHMAN SUBTREE KERNEL

Comparative Evaluation with Graph Neural Networks on the NCI1 Molecular Dataset

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Course: Machine Learning with graphs | Course Code: 23CSE479 (30 Marks)

ABSTRACT

Molecular graph classification is a foundational task in computational chemistry and chemoinformatics. In this work, we present an end-to-end, rigorous investigation of graph representation learning on the benchmark NCI1 anticancer screening dataset (4,110 molecular graphs). We manually implement the 1-dimensional Weisfeiler–Lehman (1-WL) subtree kernel strictly from scratch without reliance on prepackaged graph kernel software (such as GraKeL or NetworkX kernel utilities). We benchmark this method against two architectures: (1) a conventional non-structural graph descriptor baseline paired with an RBF Support Vector Machine (SVM), and (2) a modern 3-layer Graph Convolutional Network (GCN) implemented via PyTorch Geometric. Our empirical results demonstrate that the Weisfeiler–Lehman subtree kernel exhibits strong, monotonic performance scaling as iteration depth increases from h = 0 (52.50% accuracy) to h = 3 (75.00% accuracy, 0.7881 ROC-AUC). Furthermore, the exact discrete subtree kernel outperforms both the feature baseline (66.25%) and the GCN baseline (67.08%), while training in 0.083 seconds compared to 41.31 seconds for the GCN (a ~500x speedup). All models, metrics, unit tests, and interactive Streamlit interfaces were developed and validated reproducibly.

1. INTRODUCTION & PROBLEM FORMULATION

In chemoinformatics, molecules are naturally modeled as attributed graphs G = (V, E, l) where vertices v in V represent individual atoms, edges (u, v) in E represent chemical covalent bonds, and categorical node labeling function l: V -> Sigma assigns atomic species (e.g., C, N, O, S, P). Given a corpus of molecular graphs D = {(G_1, y_1), (G_2, y_2), ..., (G_N, y_N)}, graph classification seeks to learn a mapping f: G -> {0, 1} that accurately predicts biochemical activity. In the NCI1 benchmark, y in {0, 1} designates whether a compound inhibits the growth of human non-small cell lung cancer cell lines (1 for active, 0 for inactive).

Because graphs possess permutation symmetry (isomorphism invariance) and exhibit variable sizes, conventional vector-based machine learning algorithms cannot ingest adjacency matrices directly without imposing an arbitrary, non-canonical node ordering. Two principal paradigms have emerged: implicit feature mapping via Graph Kernels operating in a Reproducing Kernel Hilbert Space (RKHS), and parameterized permutation-equivariant neural message passing via GNNs.

2. MATHEMATICAL FORMULATION OF THE WEISFEILER–LEHMAN KERNEL

2.1 The 1-WL Color Refinement Algorithm

The 1-dimensional Weisfeiler–Lehman (1-WL) graph isomorphism test operates via iterative color refinement. Let G = (V, E) be a graph with initial discrete atom labels l_0(v) = l(v) for all v in V. For iteration t = 1, 2, ..., h, the algorithm computes new node labels via two deterministic phases:

- **Neighborhood Multiset Aggregation:** For each vertex $v \in V$, aggregate the multiset of colors from its immediate 1-hop topological neighbors N(v):

  $$M_t(v) = \{ l_{t-1}(u) : u \in N(v) \}$$

- **Deterministic Sorting & Injective Compression:** Sort $M_t(v)$ in ascending order to obtain a canonical tuple $(s_1, s_2, ..., s_k)$, and concatenate with the vertex's current label $l_{t-1}(v)$. An injective mapping g assigns a unique integer ID across all graphs:

$$l_t(v) = g(t, l_{t-1}(v), (s_1, s_2, ..., s_k))$$

2.2 Subtree Invariant & Feature Representation

A foundational property of the 1-WL refinement is that each compressed label $l_t(v)$ corresponds to an equivalence class of rooted subtree patterns of height t rooted at vertex v. Let Σ_t denote the set of all unique compressed labels discovered at iteration t across the training corpus. For a graph G, let $\phi_t(G)$ count the occurrences of each subtree pattern in G at step t:

$$\phi_t(G) = [c(G, \sigma_{t,1}), c(G, \sigma_{t,2}), ..., c(G, \sigma_{t,|\Sigma_t|})]^T$$

The comprehensive Weisfeiler–Lehman subtree feature vector $\phi(G)$ concatenates histograms across all iterations from t = 0 to h:

$$\phi(G) = [\phi_0(G)^T \mid \phi_1(G)^T \mid ... \mid \phi_h(G)^T]^T \in \Re^D, \text{ where } D = \sum_{t=0}^{h} |\Sigma_t|$$

2.3 Kernel Gram Matrix & Cosine Normalization

The unnormalized Weisfeiler–Lehman kernel between graphs G_i and G_j evaluates the inner product of their subtree histograms in the RKHS:

$$K(G_i, G_j) = \langle \phi(G_i), \phi(G_j) \rangle = \sum_{\sigma \in \Sigma} c(G_i, \sigma) \cdot c(G_j, \sigma)$$

Because molecular graphs vary in atom count (from 3 to 111 atoms in NCI1), unnormalized dot products introduce an artificial bias favoring larger compounds. To ensure valid scale-invariant topological comparisons, we apply cosine normalization:

$$K_{norm}(G_i, G_j) = K(G_i, G_j) / \sqrt{(K(G_i, G_i) \cdot K(G_j, G_j))}$$

By Mercer's Theorem, since K_{norm} is constructed via the inner product of explicit finite-dimensional feature maps $\phi(G) / \|\phi(G)\|_2$, the resulting Gram matrix $K \in \Re^{N \times N}$ is guaranteed to be symmetric ($K = K^T$) and positive semi-definite (all eigenvalues $\lambda_i \geq 0$).

3. ALGORITHMIC VERIFICATION: SEPARATING CYCLE C3 AND PATH P3

To mathematically demonstrate the discriminative power of the manual WL implementation, consider two non-isomorphic graphs having identical atom counts (|V| = 3) and identical categorical atom labels [1, 1, 1]:

• Graph A (Triangle Cycle C_3): Edges {(0, 1), (1, 2), (2, 0)}. Every vertex has degree 2.

• Graph B (Linear Path P_3): Edges {(0, 1), (1, 2)}. Center vertex 1 has degree 2, while endpoints 0 and 2 have degree 1.

At step t = 0 (atom counting alone), both graphs produce identical histogram ϕ_0 = [3.0]. An algorithm without neighborhood context cannot separate them.

At step t = 1, neighborhood multiset aggregation yields:

• For C_3: Each vertex v has neighbors {1, 1}, forming signature (t=1, label=1, neighbors=(1, 1)) → ID = 1.

• For P_3: Center vertex has neighbors {1, 1} → ID = 1; both endpoints have single neighbor {1} → ID = 2.

The resulting feature vectors are:

$\phi(C_3) = [3, 3, 0]^T$, $\phi(P_3) = [3, 1, 2]^T$

Evaluating the inner products produces the exact Gram matrix verified by our automated test suite:

$K(C_3, C_3) = 3 \cdot 3 + 3 \cdot 3 + 0 \cdot 0 = 18$

$K(P_3, P_3) = 3 \cdot 3 + 1 \cdot 1 + 2 \cdot 2 = 14$

$K(C_3, P_3) = 3 \cdot 3 + 3 \cdot 1 + 0 \cdot 2 = 12$

K = [[18, 12], [12, 14]]

The normalized similarity is $12 / \sqrt{(18 \cdot 14)} = 0.7559 < 1.0$. The 1-WL algorithm deterministically distinguishes topological connectivity.

4. ARCHITECTURAL COMPARISONS: SVM AND GRAPH CONVOLUTIONAL NETWORKS

4.1 Conventional Graph Feature Baseline + RBF SVM

To establish a rigorous baseline isolating the effect of structural subtree patterns, we extracted a 49-dimensional vector of non-structural graph descriptors: number of nodes |V|, number of edges |E|, graph density, mean/std/max vertex degree, binned degree histogram (6 bins), and normalized proportions of all 37 atom species. These features were scaled to zero mean and unit variance and classified via an RBF SVM.

4.2 Graph Convolutional Network (GCN) Formulation

We implemented a 3-layer Graph Convolutional Network following Kipf & Welling (2017). Let H^{(0)} in R^{|V| x 37} represent the one-hot atomic feature matrix, and A_tilde = A + I_N denote the adjacency matrix with added self-loops. Let D_tilde be the degree matrix of A_tilde. The layer-wise propagation rule is defined as:

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H^{(l+1)} = ReLU( D_tilde^{-1/2} A_tilde D_tilde^{-1/2} H^{(l)} W^{(l)} )
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After three graph convolution layers with dropout (p = 0.3) and hidden dimension d = 64, global mean pooling aggregates node representations into a graph embedding: h_G = (1 / |V|) sum_{v in V} h_v^{(3)}. A 2-layer MLP classification head projects h_G to logits. The model is optimized via cross-entropy loss and Adam (lr = 0.005, weight decay = 1e-4) with early stopping on validation loss.

5. EMPIRICAL BENCHMARK EVALUATION ON NCI1

Experiments were conducted under strict stratified 70% / 10% / 20% splits (Train: 840, Val: 120, Test: 240). To strictly avoid test-set leakage, the WL vocabulary Sigma was fitted solely on training graphs, and test graphs were projected into the fitted vocabulary before computing the K_{test, train} in R^{N_{test} x N_{train}} rectangular kernel matrix.

Model Architecture	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	ROC-AUC	Train Time
Graph Feature Baseline + RBF SVM	0.6625	0.6757	0.6250	0.6494	0.7125	0.042 s
WL Subtree Kernel (h = 0) + SVM	0.5250	0.5188	0.6917	0.5929	0.5823	0.021 s
WL Subtree Kernel (h = 1) + SVM	0.6583	0.6900	0.5750	0.6273	0.7078	0.042 s
WL Subtree Kernel (h = 2) + SVM	0.7125	0.7576	0.6250	0.6849	0.7685	0.062 s
WL Subtree Kernel (h = 3) + SVM	**0.7500**	**0.7885**	**0.6833**	**0.7321**	**0.7881**	**0.083 s**
3-Layer GCN Baseline (PyG)	0.6708	0.6783	0.6500	0.6638	0.7594	41.307 s

6. RESEARCH ANALYSIS & THEORETICAL INSIGHTS

1. Impact of Subtree Depth h: At h = 0, the model acts purely as a 'bag of atoms' counter, ignoring bond connectivity and achieving only 52.50% accuracy. At h = 1, accuracy surges by +13.33% to 65.83%, demonstrating that 1-hop bond configurations (functional groups) provide immediate discriminative signal. At h = 2 and h = 3, accuracy climbs to 71.25% and 75.00% respectively (ROC-AUC 0.7881). The vocabulary grows from 26 features at h=0 to 10,282 features at h=3.

2. Expressive Power Bound of GNNs: Morris et al. (2019) and Xu et al. (2019) proved that standard message-passing GNNs with mean aggregation are at most as powerful as the 1-WL isomorphism test in distinguishing non-isomorphic graphs. Our results empirically confirm this bound: the exact discrete 1-WL subtree kernel achieves 75.00% accuracy, whereas the continuous 3-layer GCN achieves 67.08%. On discrete chemical benchmarks, the exact discrete multiset enumeration coupled with convex SVM dual optimization avoids the optimization difficulties and potential over-smoothing of gradient-trained neural layers.

3. Computational Complexity & Scalability: Feature extraction for the WL kernel completed in 0.083 seconds, whereas GCN training required 41.31 seconds (~500x slower). The WL kernel provides deterministic, reproducible results without seed stochasticity.

7. DEPLOYMENT & ACADEMIC REPRODUCIBILITY DELIVERABLES

To satisfy the academic evaluation requirements, this project provides: • **Full Modular Codebase:** Organized under src/ with data loading, preprocessing, WL kernel, SVM, baseline, and GCN modules. • **Automated Test Suite:** 7 unit tests (pytest) verifying mathematical kernel symmetry, Mercer non-negativity, deterministic hashing, and C3 vs P3 separation. • **Interactive Streamlit Dashboard (app.py):** Renders molecular graph visualizations, step-by-step subtree relabeling, comparative benchmark tables, and live compound inference. • **Deployment Readiness:** Configured with .streamlit/config.toml, standalone cached model weights (models/wl_clf_h2.pkl), and instructions for GitHub publication at github.com/Vishal-Karthikeyan-S.

8. REFERENCES

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